POWER BUILDING



A Board Member's Guide

JUSTICE OUTSIDE 2026

Thank you for the work you do on this board. Justice Outside is able to do what we do because of the time, the relationships, and the trust you bring to it.

Power-building is the practice at the center of our work. It's how we describe the way Justice Outside resources grassroots leaders, advocates alongside community, and develops the people shaping the future of this movement. The term is still new to a lot of the field, which is part of why the language we use around it matters.

This guide gives us shared language for those conversations. When we describe power-building clearly, funders understand what their dollars actually unlock, peers see why our model is different from what they've funded before, and the communities at the center of our work are represented well.

How to Use this Guide

Three sections live in this document.

- The Framework explains what power-building is, how the three pillars work together, and why all three matter at once.
- Why This Works offers the evidence, the data, and the grantee partner story that help the model land in a real conversation.
- How to Talk About It prepares you for the questions, the language choices, and the pushback you may hear from funders, peers, and partners.

Please note: Use this as a reference, not a script. Speak in your own voice.

PART ONE: THE FRAMEWORK

Our Vision: A just world where Black, Indigenous, and Communities of Color experience safety, health, and abundant joy through meaningful relationships with one another and the outdoors.

Our Mission: Justice Outside advances racial justice and equity in the outdoor and environmental movement. We shift resources to, build power with, and center the voices and leadership of Black, Indigenous, and People of Color. The health of current and future generations depends on it.

Power-Building: Power-building is the intentional and strategic practice of resourcing grassroots leaders to share wisdom, co-create strategies, and drive collective impact.

Communities most affected by environmental injustice move into real decision-making power. They shape the legislation, funding, and policies that govern their outdoor spaces and natural resources.

THE THREE PILLARS

Our work runs through three connected pillars.

Advocate · Policy & Voice

We coordinate coalitions and run advocacy hubs in California, Washington, and Pennsylvania, along with our National Advocacy Hub, Root Hub. Our advocacy agenda centers four areas where community voice is most urgently needed:

- Indigenous Sovereignty and Land Rematriation
- Green Jobs and Blue Economies
- Healing and Wellness
- Environmental Education

Our grantee partners and program alumnx become the advocates shaping policy on the issues that affect their land, water, and outdoor spaces.

Fund · Resources & Trust

We move flexible, renewable grants of $10,000 to $40,000 annually to community-led organizations, for four to six years at a time. There is no 501(c)(3) requirement and no rigid reporting demands. Our funding priorities are:

- Health and Wellness
- Land and Water Access
- Grassroots Organizing and Mobilization
- Youth Education
- Economic Opportunity.

Build · Leaders & Networks

We grow the leaders shaping the future of this movement through three signature programs: the Rising Leaders Fellowship, Network for Network Leaders (in partnership with Lawrence Hall of Science), and Pathfinders. In 2025, that meant 58 fellows from 52 organizations across 15 states.

THE POWER CYCLE

Each pillar feeds the next. Every rotation builds more power than the last.

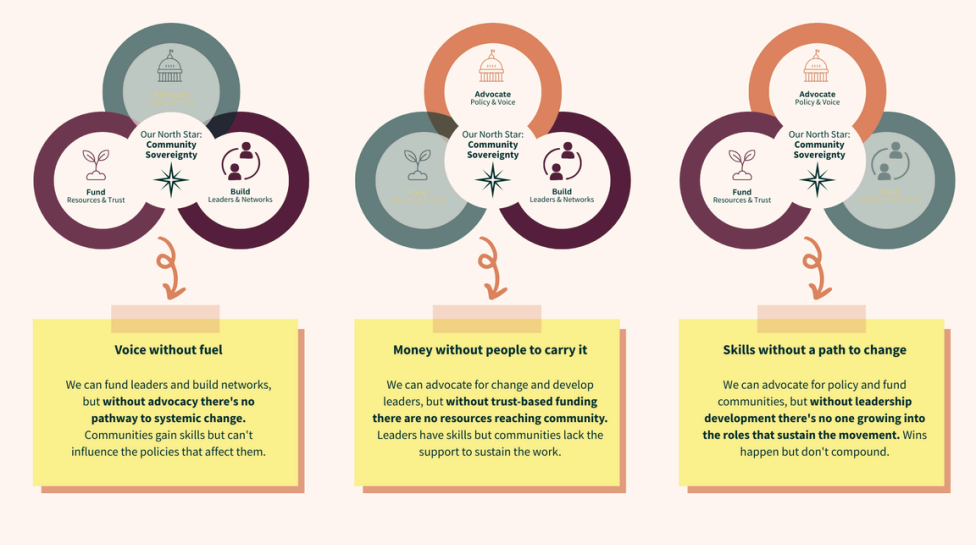
1. **We are grounded in community.** Grassroots leaders, grantees, fellows, and community members tell us what they need. We listen first.
2. **We advocate for policy change.** Community priorities become our campaign priorities. Grantees and program alumni are trained and supported as grassroots advocates.
3. **We fund community-led solutions.** Trust-based grants put dollars and decision-making power in community hands at the same time.
4. **We build leadership and networks.** Fellowships, learning labs, and consulting grow leaders and connect them to each other.
5. **Leaders return to community with more power.** What they bring back shapes our next round of advocacy. What they learn shapes our next round of funding. The cycle compounds.

"When all three pillars are building power together, communities don't just gain access. They gain the power to decide what happens in their outdoor spaces, their communities, and their future."

WHAT BREAKS WITHOUT ALL THREE

One of the most common questions you'll get is some version of, "couldn't you just focus on one of these and do it really well?" The honest answer is no.

The three pillars working together is what allows communities to make the decisions that govern their outdoor spaces, their resources, and their future.



A Quick Clarification

There are two things power-building gets confused with.

Power-building is not just grantmaking. Money is one part of a larger cycle that also includes leadership development and advocacy. Funders who treat us as a regranter are missing what the model actually produces.

Power-building is also not DEI work. It is environmental justice. The conversation is about who makes decisions on land, water, and outdoor spaces, not about representation alone.

WHAT CHANGES WHEN POWER SHIFTS

We're building toward a future where organizations led by Black, Indigenous, and People of Color aren't just included in the environmental movement. They're shaping it.

- **Systems get rebuilt.** The barriers that limit who holds power, representation, and influence get rebuilt as equitable systems.
- **Community Leadership.** Decision-making shifts to the people most affected. Community leaders don't get consulted. They lead.
- **Environmental Justice.** The people closest to environmental harm design the response. Solutions come from the ground up.
- **Access to Outdoor Spaces.** Parks, trails, waterways, and green spaces become safe, welcoming, and accessible for Black, Indigenous, and Communities of Color.
- **Equitable Resources.** Funding flows directly to communities of color, closing the gaps that decades of philanthropic racial bias created.

PART TWO: WHY THIS WORKS

In 2025, Bowman Performance Consulting completed a year-long independent evaluation of our trust-based grantmaking practice. Two findings stand out:

- **96 percent of grantee partners reported improved financial stability** through the partnership.
- **95 percent described our process as co-designed and supportive.**

For many of our grantee partners, that financial stability has meant the difference between staying open and closing their doors.

Read the full evaluation: From Trust to Transformation: How Justice Outside is Redefining Grantmaking for Equity and Impact

In February 2026, Justice Outside co-authored *The Nature Gap: Communities of Color and Those With Low Incomes Are Bearing the Brunt of America's Nature Loss* with the Center for American Progress and Conservation Science Partners. The report updates the landmark 2020 analysis with new data covering every census tract in the contiguous United States, and for the first time it connects nature deprivation directly to pollution exposure and climate risk at a national scale.

A few of the findings to keep close:

- 74 percent of people living in nature-deprived areas are communities of color
- 77 percent of communities facing both the greatest pollution and the greatest nature loss are communities of color
- 70 percent of nature-deprived communities are severely cost-burdened, spending more than half their income on housing
- Extreme heat zones are 1.4 times more likely to overlap with nature-deprived areas

"This data confirms what frontline communities have long known. Nature loss is not random. It is the result of centuries of policy choices rooted in discrimination. The communities bearing the greatest burden are also the ones building the most powerful solutions." — Kim Bailey, President and CEO, report co-author

The report also features eleven of our grantee partners who are closing the nature gap from the ground up, from Indigenous land stewardship in rural North Carolina to community-driven air quality monitoring in Seattle to coastal land rights protection on the Sea Islands of South Carolina. The data names the scale of the gap. Our grantee partners are showing what it looks like to close it.

Read the full report: *The Nature Gap*

A STORY WORTH KNOWING: MAYRA PELAGIO

Mayra is one of our grantee partners, and her path through Justice Outside is the clearest example we have of how the three pillars feed each other in one leader's career.

She first came to us through our Network for Network Leaders program as the executive director of LUNA, an immigrant and housing justice nonprofit in San Jose. She was uncertain about her own leadership qualifications when she applied. By the time the program ended, she had founded her own consulting firm, Ignite Community Connections, and launched Reconnect Outdoors, which brings monolingual Spanish-speaking Latinx immigrants in San Jose into nearby outdoor spaces they had never had access to.

The story doesn't end there. Mayra used the visioning and organizing tools she

developed through Network for Network Leaders to guide her community through a campaign opposing lead exposure from San Jose's Reid-Hillview Airport. Community members translated their visions for the space into concrete policy proposals. As of 2025, Santa Clara County is no longer accepting FAA funds for Reid-Hillview Airport, and the county plans to close it by 2031.

That outcome reflects every pillar at work. Mayra received flexible, trust-based funding through our grantmaking. She built skills, networks, and confidence through our leadership development. And she led an advocacy campaign that ended in a real policy win for her community.

"Beyond funding, beyond relationships, we need to be able to make the policy. We need to be able to be in these decision-making spaces that allow us to build the community we deserve." — Mayra Pelagio

When funders or peers ask you what power-building actually produces, Mayra's story is one of the clearest answers we have.

PART THREE: HOW TO TALK ABOUT IT

The framework, the data, and the stories are useful, but only if we have language we can actually carry into a conversation. This section is the practical layer. The phrases, pitches, and answers that will help you walk into any room and represent the work clearly, in your own voice.

Phrases Worth Knowing

A few sentences carry a lot of weight on their own. Use the ones that feel natural.

- "We don't fund projects. We fund power."
- "We don't advocate for communities. We advocate with them."
- "We don't set the priorities. Communities do."
- "We're not training people to participate in the movement as it is. We're developing the people who will transform it."

LANGUAGE THAT LANDS

We've learned over the years that some words open doors and others quietly close them. The table below is what we use across the organization, and what we steer away from.

Use this	Instead of
Grantee partners	Grantees, recipients, awardees
Trust-based, flexible, renewable funding	Awarded grants
Community-led	Underrepresented, voiceless
National environmental justice intermediary	National nonprofit
Black, Indigenous, and People of Color (spelled out)	BIPOC
Overlooked by traditional philanthropy	Marginalized

HOW TO INTRODUCE JUSTICE OUTSIDE

When you only have a sentence or two, this is the version we use across the organization. Adjust to your audience, but stay rooted in it.

"Justice Outside is a national environmental justice intermediary led by Black, Indigenous, and People of Color. We shift resources to, build power with, and center the voices and leadership of community leaders most affected by environmental injustice. We do this through three connected pillars: Advocate, Fund, and Build."

YOUR 30-SECOND PITCH

A starting point for chance encounters and brief introductions. Adapt it so it sounds like you.

"Justice Outside is a national environmental justice intermediary led by Black, Indigenous, and People of Color. We move flexible, trust-based funding to grassroots organizations and develop the leaders shaping the future of this movement. Last year we moved more than $4 million to 180+ community-led organizations. I serve on the board because [your why]."

YOUR 2-MINUTE VERSION

For when you have a real conversation with a funder or peer.

"Justice Outside is a national environmental justice intermediary based in Oakland. Our work runs through three connected pillars: Advocate, Fund, and Build.

On the funding side, we move flexible, trust-based grants of $10,000 to $40,000 to community-led organizations, with no 501(c)(3) requirement. Last year we moved more than $4 million to 180+ organizations. An independent evaluation by Bowman Performance Consulting found that 96 percent of our grantee partners reported improved financial stability through the partnership.

Our advocacy work happens through coalitions and through our advocacy hubs in California, Washington, and Pennsylvania. Community leaders speak directly in policy rooms, and we provide the infrastructure that makes that possible.

On the leadership side, our Rising Leaders Fellowship onboarded 58 fellows from 52 organizations in 15 states last year alone.

What makes the model work is that those three pillars feed each other. That integration is part of why we won the ABFE 2026 Institutional Award for Philanthropic Leadership."

QUESTIONS YOU MIGHT BE ASKED

A few of the most common questions, with answers that have worked well in real conversations.

What does Justice Outside do?
We're a national environmental justice intermediary led by Black, Indigenous, and People of Color. We move flexible, trust-based funding to community-led grassroots organizations, coordinate advocacy that turns community priorities into policy, and develop the leaders shaping the future of the environmental movement.

What is an intermediary?
An organization that sits between funders and grassroots groups. We move resources from philanthropy to community-led organizations that traditional philanthropy often cannot reach directly. We are part funder, part field-builder, and part connector.

How is Justice Outside different from other environmental organizations?
Most environmental organizations focus on one piece, whether that's conservation, advocacy, or education. We focus on power. We resource and coordinate so the communities most affected by environmental injustice can lead the response themselves. The integrated three-pillar model is what sets us apart.

Where does Justice Outside work?
We are a national organization. Our grantee partners, fellows, and network leaders are based in communities across the country, with concentrations in the Bay Area, the West Coast, the Southwest, the Delaware River Watershed, the Great Lakes, the Southern United States, and the Carolinas. Our advocacy hubs are based in California, Washington, and Pennsylvania.

Why fund through an intermediary instead of going direct?
A few reasons. Our grantee partners are usually outside traditional philanthropic networks, and we have spent 15 years building those relationships. We absorb the compliance and reporting load that would otherwise fall on grantees. And every grant we move is paired with leadership development and advocacy training that direct grantmaking cannot easily provide.

What is trust-based grantmaking?
Long-term, flexible, low-bureaucracy funding that respects grantee time and capacity. We start with the belief that grassroots groups already have the answers to the challenges they face. We use video and phone applications, simplified reporting, and one-on-one support. The complexity sits with us, not with grantee partners.

How does Justice Outside measure impact?
Through ongoing relationships with grantee partners, regular evaluation, and the year-long independent study Bowman Performance Consulting released in 2025. We also track advocacy wins, leadership outcomes, and shifts in how trust-based grantmaking is understood across the field.

Are you a 501(c)(3)? Can you lobby?
Yes, Justice Outside is a 501(c)(3) public charity. We do not lobby in the technical legal sense. What we do is nonpartisan advocacy, which is fully permissible under our tax status.

What if I get a question I cannot answer?
Say so, and offer to follow up. Something like, "That's a great question. Let me check with the team and circle back to you." Then loop in Justice Outside's Chief Program Officer and/or the Director of Communications and Advocacy.

When Someone Pushes Back

You'll hear skepticism from time to time, especially from peer funders. Here are a few responses that have worked well in real conversations.

When someone says, "Isn't this just regranting?"
"It would be, if grantmaking were the only thing we did. The integration is what makes our model different. Every grant we move is paired with leadership development and advocacy infrastructure, and the outcomes reflect that."

When someone says, "I'd rather fund direct."
"Some funders can, and that's wonderful. Most cannot reach the organizations we work with, because our grantee partners are often the ones without 501(c)(3) status, without a national funder relationship, or without the staff capacity to manage traditional compliance. We've spent 15 years building those relationships specifically so funding can reach them."

When someone questions trust-based grantmaking.
"Trust-based does not mean no rigor. It means rigor that fits grantee capacity. We meet every legal and funder compliance standard. We absorb the complexity ourselves instead of passing it through to grantees, and that's a deliberate choice."

If a conversation ever gets harder than this guide can hold, please bring it back to the Chief Program Officer and/or the Director of Communications and Advocacy.

IN CLOSING

Thank you for taking the time to sit with this guide. Power-building is a lot to carry. The framework, the language, the evidence, and the questions you'll get all take time to settle in, and we don't expect any of it to feel automatic right away.

What we do know is that the conversations ahead of us, with funders, with peers, with the people in your networks who have never heard the term before, are the conversations that move this work forward. The role you play in those rooms is part of how power-building reaches further than we could on our own.

If anything in this guide raises a question, a hesitation, or an idea for how we could make it more useful, please bring it to Bren or Kim. We'd rather hear from you than have you carry it alone.